strongest advocates of training and used to come quite often to Prabodhini'. Sahasrabuddhe recalls: 'Advaniji was fond of recalling a story on the need for training politicians by Shail Chaturvedi, a humourist-poet who was present at the BJP's 1980 plenary session. As the story narrated by Advaniji went: a newly appointed minister told his driver that he will drive the car today. The driver turned around and said that, in this case, he will get down. Try and drive, he said, your soul will get shaken. This is a car, not a government that can run *bhagwan bharose* [trusting in God alone].'[100]

While the massive spurt in the BJP's expansion started under Amit Shah in 2014, much of the early work for it had started under the first presidency of Rajnath Singh between 2005 and 2009. 'I started seeing a party which was in construction mode,' recalls Vani Tripathi Tikoo, who served as national secretary during that time. 'It was very much like when the old building gets demolished and a new one is constructed. The question was how you deconstruct the old and you start building on the new. Narendra Modi emerged at the same time as an important national leader. He was already very powerful in Gujarat and Rajnath Singh built a brand-new team at the centre after the debacle of the 2004 campaign.'[101]

At the central level, this was the period when the BJP started inducting new faces in key positions in its various cells: Smriti Irani started to gain importance as president of the party's women's wing, several young legislators from Bihar became national executive members of the youth wing, Piyush Goyal was made the party's national treasurer and Arvind Gupta was brought in to revamp the IT Cell. 'I saw several rank newcomers getting important positions in various cells of the party,' recalls Tikoo.

This rebuilding took on another dimension under Nitin Gadkari, who served as party president in the 2009–2013 period. Gadkari, a politician from Nagpur who had a strong equation with the RSS, also brought with him Mumbai-style corporate governance. 'He was an MBA by training and refused to accept the kurta-pyjama culture of the party,' recalls a party leader who worked closely with him. 'He was different from the Delhi and UP political class. He dressed in shirts and pants, spoke his mind, even using cusswords in meetings, and would be hands-on with the party cadres.' The result was that a